
Where Did Things Go So Wrong for Trump on the Epstein Story? We Can Pinpoint It Exactly!

Published by

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Estimated reading time

10 min

Added on

2025-07-25

Address

<https://slate.com/news-and-politics/2025/07/trump-epstein-files-pam-bondi-doj-why.html>

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On Wednesday, the Wall Street Journal [reported](#) that back in May, Attorney General Pam Bondi “informed the president at a meeting in the White House that his name was in the Epstein files.” This is wild news, and not just because the president in question is Donald Trump, the guy from the [1980s tabloid bankruptcies](#)! That’s a whole long story for another time. Let’s talk Epstein.

There is really such a thing as “the Epstein files”? I thought that was a kind of made-up thing for people who spend too much time online.

Yeah, us too! For a long time, the story of Jeffrey Epstein operated on two tracks. First, there was the “[what we actually know](#)” track, in which the well-connected Wall Street figure settled a criminal investigation into his sexual abuse of teenage girls by accepting a controversially lenient 2008 plea deal from federal prosecutors in Florida, but was then charged again with sex trafficking in 2019 by federal prosecutors in New York, and was then found dead in a jail cell later that year of what appeared to be a self-inflicted hanging. In this version of the story, i.e., the “what could actually be proven and printed in a legitimate publication without inviting a lawsuit” version, Epstein was known to have socialized and traveled at various times with a wide variety of other powerful and famous men—including two presidents, [Bill Clinton](#) and [Trump](#). But none of them were ever accused by authorities of participating in criminal sexual conduct in Epstein’s presence, and all denied knowledge of his crimes.

On the *second* track, which traversed modern American society’s expansive realm of speculation and conspiracy theory, Epstein was said to have kept a “client list” of men to whom he’d provided child prostitutes, used that list for purposes of blackmail, and been the victim of a staged jailhouse “suicide” carried out to prevent him from naming names. “The Epstein files” became shorthand, in this conversation, for inflammatory and incriminating material that had been gathered at some point by law enforcement but was being suppressed in order to protect powerful elite pedophiles.

It was always a known, real fact that there was material related to the investigations into Epstein that wasn’t public, right? Grand jury transcripts, that sort of thing.

Yes. But there are normal, nonconspiratorial [reasons](#) not to release all the material generated by criminal investigations. One is the privacy of people who were victims of crimes. Another is that investigations can involve research into individuals who were never charged with a crime because authorities determined that they never did anything illegal or that there was not enough evidence to support a case against them. From the rational/empirical perspective, it seemed very possible that there was no wider concerted effort to suppress information about Epstein, especially given that the known facts about his behavior—and what was, *at best*, a failure by the [elites around him](#) to realize what he was doing—were abhorrent enough on their own.

OK, then why are we talking about releasing all this stuff?

You’ll never guess who promised to do it!

Donald Trump? The New York real estate executive?

That's right! During the 2024 presidential campaign, Trump—and surrogates like his son Don Jr., J.D. Vance, and Elon Musk—told [pretty much anyone who would listen](#) that he would release any and all Epstein files or lists that were in the government's possession. This was good for them at the time because Epstein's case was a subject of great interest to many younger-skewing, not-particularly-partisan voters to whom Trump wanted to come across as an outsider who was not beholden to the establishment. It was also an object of fixation for MAGA mega-partisans and QAnon believers who believed that Epstein materials would specifically implicate a network of pedophile Democrats.

Sounds like the kind of promise that you would make during a campaign and then come up with excuses not to follow through on, if you were, for example, an old friend of Jeffrey Epstein's.

Right. Except that Trump—and, at this point, most of the people around him—exists within an a powerful anti-reality bubble. A basic premise you are required to uphold at this point in order to work for the Trump White House, for instance, is that he won the 2020 election. The almost superhuman ability to not feel shame or admit wrongdoing has, in many ways, usually been his greatest *strength* as a political figure. So when Trump took office, he appointed a variety of right-wing super-loyalists to top law enforcement jobs, and they began operating under the premise that they needed to release “the Epstein files” so as to duly expose the network of elite and predominantly Democratic pedophiles who were supposedly implicated therein.

Trump's attorney general, Pam Bondi, initially intersected with him in 2013 when she was attorney general of Florida and he [coincidentally donated to her reelection campaign](#) while she was deciding whether or not to investigate fraud complaints against the “Trump University” real-estate seminar scheme. After receiving Trump's donation, Bondi judiciously chose *not* to investigate his seminars, and in fact later became [one of his defense attorneys](#). In February, shortly after taking office as the U.S. AG, Bondi told Fox News the [Epstein client list was on her desk for review](#) and touted an “Epstein Files, Part I” document release.

Right-wing influencers criticized the initial release, though, as a [rehash of old news](#). And according to a [letter released by Democratic Illinois Sen. Dick Durbin](#), who is the ranking Dem on the Senate committee that oversees the FBI and Department of Justice, his office has been told Bondi responded to the influencer backlash by putting an estimated 1,000 FBI staffers onto the job of reviewing “approximately 100,000 Epstein-related records in order to produce more documents.” Those individuals, Durbin's letter says, “were instructed to ‘flag’ any records in which President Trump was mentioned.”

So not only did Bondi promise to release the Epstein files, she (according to Durbin) directed the FBI to compile a centralized list of the times that her boss, the president, was mentioned in them?

It seems that the administration may have not applied its usual level of forethought and analytical rigor to this decision.

Why didn't Trump stop her from doing this?

See above re: superhuman levels of self-delusion that typically function as an asset.

This is kind of like if Richard Nixon had announced the day after the Watergate break-in that he was ordering a thorough investigation of whether the Watergate break-in could be connected to Richard Nixon.

It's kind of like that, sure. As a matter of scandal management only, and not an analogy about guilt or innocence of any crime.

What happened when they ... found his name?

According to the Journal, in May, Bondi “informed the president at a meeting in the White House that his name was in the Epstein files.” (To reiterate, this does not imply that Trump was ever suspected of a crime.) At that meeting, the two reportedly agreed not to release any more Epstein material. In early July, Bondi posted a [memo](#) announcing that decision, in which the DOJ and FBI asserted that no “client list” existed, and that Epstein had died by suicide. The DOJ also released what it described as “full” and “raw” surveillance video from the facility at which Epstein was found dead (which [turned out to have been edited](#) and did not actually show his cell). All that is what set off the current explosion of interest in the subject, during which Trump [explicitly denied](#) that his name was mentioned in any of the documents at issue.

OK. Is the president going to suffer political or personal consequences from lying about whether his name was mentioned in documents generated during a sex trafficking and sexual abuse investigation, or from personally approving his subordinate’s decision to keep those documents hidden from the public?

Hey, maybe! An Economist/YouGov [poll](#) finds that 56 percent of Americans disapprove of his handling of the Epstein situation against only 22 percent who approve. On Wednesday, three Republican members of the House Oversight Committee [joined the panel’s Democrats](#) in passing a motion to subpoena the DOJ’s Epstein materials—notable defections given the level of control Trump usually exerts over his party. Republican Speaker of the House Mike Johnson [canceled](#) Thursday’s scheduled session, sending the chamber into its August recess a day early, over what [reports](#) have described as his members’ uneasiness with being asked to cast votes that could be seen as abetting an Epstein cover-up.

Are MAGA die-hards really starting to believe that Donald Trump might have done something wrong?

That’s unclear, although Trump has not gotten much traction on his claim that Barack Obama [did things that are a bigger deal than the Epstein case](#) and/or created the “[Epstein hoax](#).” Either way, Democrats (and wavering Republicans) are probably more concerned with the aforementioned younger and less partisan voter demographic. In that sphere—the Joe Rogan Zone, if you will—Trump has already been the subject of criticism for [failing to end the war in Gaza](#) and [trampling on the due process rights of immigrants](#).

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What's next?

Well, representatives of Trump's Department of Justice are [meeting Thursday](#) with Ghislaine Maxwell, Epstein's longtime friend and literal partner in crime, who was herself convicted of sex trafficking and grooming offenses and sentenced to 20 years in prison. Ostensibly, they are there to seek "information about anyone who has committed crimes against victims"—but anyone who has a passing familiarity with Donald Trump's career or has seen a single "political thriller"-type movie is likely assuming that she is going to be offered a presidential pardon in exchange for saying that Trump had nothing to do with anything bad that Epstein ever did.

Is that going to work?

This is just one man's opinion, but: No, I think would be too obvious of a quid pro quo to fool anyone—even the median American voter, bless his heart. It will also do nothing to stop the flow of information about Trump's connections to Epstein that is coming from other sources. His administration is, as they say, currently leaking like a sieve; [the Journal reported](#), for instance, that FBI director Kash Patel "has privately told other government officials that Trump's name appeared in the [Epstein] files," which is probably not something Kash Patel wishes that the world knew. Somehow, the newspaper also obtained what appears to be a 50th birthday card that Trump wrote to Epstein that references a "[wonderful secret](#)" that they share. (Trump denies that he wrote the card and is [suing the Journal](#).) Democratic Sen. Ron Wyden has been pressing to release [information about Epstein's financial transactions](#). The Republicans taking their August vacation are probably going to get asked quite a bit about this stuff.

Trump is also a figure whose approval rating was [declining](#) even before his Epstein connections popped up again; none of his policies are [popular](#), inflation is [going up](#), and he's been mainly using his presidency to [pick on a lot of people](#) who would [now love to see him go down for any reason](#). In the past few days, high-volume news consumers who already knew about Trump's many public connections to Epstein—and the [many sexual assault allegations against Trump](#)—may have been asking themselves: OK, but why is this happening *now*? It's a fair question—but in the end, the biggest lesson of the Trump Era in the United States might be that things don't have to happen for good reasons.

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